



Chapter 6

User personas

Ages 18-22 · college and early independence

The player is the adult now. No parent holding the phone, no co-play, no syllabus: just a young adult in a new city, hitting consent, dating, money, health and rights for the first time, for real. The canvas goes dark and the voice goes wry. India-segmented personas for the people who were taught none of this and are learning it at full speed.

Nobody hands you a manual at 18.

Chapters 1-5 always had an adult in the room. Chapter 6 doesn't. The player has left home, often for a new city, and is meeting consent, dating apps, contraception, rent, harassment and a bank balance for the first time, usually with no prior education and real consequences attached. Bias doesn't retire when you grow up, and neither does the learning. The canvas goes dark, the voice goes wry-but-kind, and the product stops being a guide for a child and becomes a confidant for an adult.

Four shifts from the Kids chapters

SHIFT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT THE DESIGN MUST DO
The learner is the user	No parent operating the device; full autonomy and full responsibility.	Speak adult-to-adult; respect their intelligence and privacy.
Life is the syllabus	They learn when they hit a wall: a match, a clinic, a creep at work, a money panic.	Just-in-time and searchable, not a linear course.
The stakes are real	Consent, STIs, rent, harassment and debt have actual consequences now.	Practical survival skills: health, money, rights, relationships.
Family goes remote	Parents become distant pressure (marriage, money, reputation), not co-players.	Help navigate autonomy versus family, without rupture.

Eight personas: six young-adult users across Indian segments, and two reach channels. Each ends in design implications for the nine Chapter 6 games: Consent For Real, Swipe Right, Real Relationships, Own Your Health, Money & Independence, Mind & Belonging, Find Your Feet, Equal & Confident, and Know Your Rights.

Six players, two doorways.

At 18-22 the cast is mostly the users themselves. Family is off-screen pressure; the people who can still reach them at scale are a campus counsellor and an NGO that works where campuses don't.

PERSONA	ROLE	SEGMENT	IN ONE LINE	THE LEVER FOR DEPTH
Ananya, 19	User	Protected home → metro college	Freedom, dating apps, zero prior sex ed.	Consent and safety, judgment-free.
Rohan, 20	User	Urban college	Tate-fed teen, now dating real women.	Relearn respect; survive rejection.
Deepak, 20	User	First-gen, low-income	First in his family here, and feels it.	Belonging, money, a future.
Zoya, 21	User	Urban college	Found herself in college; dreads going home.	Affirm; family without rupture.
Meena, 20	User	Rural-to-urban migrant worker	Working, alone, no campus safety net.	Rights, money, health, dignity.
Aarti, 21	User	Tier-2, local degree	Her marriage is being arranged around her.	A say in her own life.
Dr. Mehta, 45	Channel	Campus counsellor	One counsellor, a campus in crisis.	Just-in-time, destigmatised, referral.
Farhan, 33	Channel	NGO youth programme	Reaches the youth no campus does.	Offline, in-language adulting and rights.

Ananya, 19

Second-year student · metro college, from a protected tier-2 home · the freedom shock

"At home I couldn't talk to a boy. Now there's a whole app of them, parties, and nobody ever told me how any of this actually works."

LIVES	Hostel in a metro; first time away from a strict home.
MONEY	Family allowance; learning to budget for the first time.
DEVICES	Own phone, fully private; on Instagram and a dating app.
SUPPORT	New friends, no family nearby, parents who call daily.
PRIOR ED	None worth the name; "don't talk to boys" was the curriculum.

First semester. Ananya went from a house where dating was forbidden to a campus where everyone seems experienced. It is thrilling and bewildering. She matched with someone, went to his room, and froze, unsure what she'd agreed to or whether she was allowed to change her mind. She has questions about consent, alcohol, contraception and safety she cannot ask her parents and is embarrassed to ask new friends.

What she wants

- To enjoy her freedom without getting hurt or used.
- Straight answers on consent, safety and contraception, no judgment.
- To know how dating apps actually work, and how to stay safe on them.
- To stop feeling like the only one who doesn't know the rules.

The myth she carries

Years of "don't" with no "how". She half-believes that wanting freedom is shameful, and that going somewhere with a man forfeits her right to say no.

If you went to his room, you can't say no.

Good girls don't want this.

She needs permission to be an adult and the facts to do it safely.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything moralising about "good girls" or scaring her off dating.
- A school-module tone; she has left all that behind.
- Content that assumes she already knows the basics.

BORING TO ANANYA

A finger-wagging "risks of dating" lecture. It sounds like the parents she just moved away from.

MAGIC TO ANANYA

A frank, non-judgmental guide to consent, apps and safety that treats her like a capable adult making her own choices.

Design implications

- 1 Lead with consent for real adult settings: alcohol, a room, the right to change your mind any time.
- 2 Teach dating-app safety practically: meet in public, tell a friend, trust your gut, no obligation.
- 3 Make contraception and sexual health easy, private and shame-free to learn.
- 4 Drop the school tone; speak to her as the adult she now is.

Rohan, 20

Engineering student · urban college · the manosphere kid, grown up and confused

"I did everything the videos said. I still got rejected, and I still feel alone. Maybe the videos were the problem."

LIVES	Shared flat; second city; lots of online time, few close friends.
MONEY	Family-funded; anxious about job prospects.
DEVICES	Deep in gaming, Reddit and dating apps; years of "red pill" intake.
SUPPORT	A male friend group that reinforces the same scripts.
PRIOR ED	The internet raised him on this; school taught him nothing.

Reality check. Rohan absorbed the manosphere as a teen, the Veer of Chapter 4 a few years on. Now he is actually trying to date, and the playbook is failing him: women aren't responding to the "alpha" act, rejection stings, and he is lonelier than ever. He is at a fork: double down on resentment, or quietly suspect he was sold a lie. He will not respond to being called a misogynist. He might respond to "that stuff is making you miserable, here's why".

What he wants

- To actually connect with someone, and to stop feeling like a failure.
- To understand why the "rules" he learned keep backfiring.
- A version of being a man that works and that he can respect.
- Real talk about rejection, loneliness and self-worth.

The myth he carries

A worldview sold to a lonely teenager: that dominance wins, that women are adversaries, that rejection is a verdict on his worth.

Be alpha and they'll come.

Rejection means you're worthless.

The exit is through his own disappointment, not through being told off.

Why he'd bounce

- Being lectured about toxic masculinity; instant defensiveness.
- Anything that sounds like it sides against men.
- Earnest, preachy tone; he respects sharp, not soft.

BACKFIRES FOR ROHAN

A module on respecting women. He's heard it as "you're the bad guy" and tunes out.

MAGIC TO ROHAN

An honest take on why the playbook is making him miserable, plus a real, respected way to be a man and to handle rejection.

Design implications

- 1 Enter through his pain (loneliness, rejection), not his politics; never lecture.
- 2 Offer a confident, respectful masculinity that actually works in real relationships.
- 3 Normalise rejection and self-worth beyond dating "wins".
- 4 Use a sharp, wry register he respects; earnestness loses him.

Deepak, 20

First-generation student · government college, far from home · the impostor

"Everyone here seems to know how things work. I'm sending money home, doing tuitions on the side, and pretending I belong."

LIVES	Cheap shared room; first in his family at college.
MONEY	Scholarship plus part-time work; sends money home; counts every rupee.
DEVICES	One phone; data managed; not much time to spare.
SUPPORT	Few connections; nobody at home understands campus life.
PRIOR ED	Strong in studies; lost on money, networks and "soft" rules.

Holding it together. Deepak fought his way here and now battles a quieter enemy: the sense that he doesn't belong. He's managing money for the first time, anxious about jobs in a market that seems rigged toward the connected, and reluctant to ask for help in case it confirms he's out of his depth. His competence is real; his confidence and his information are not.

What he wants

- To belong here without pretending, and to make it count.
- Practical money skills: budgeting, saving, avoiding debt traps.
- A realistic path through career anxiety and a tough job market.
- To know it's normal to struggle, and okay to ask for help.

The myth he carries

That people like him don't belong in places like this, and that needing help is proof he doesn't.

People like me don't belong here.

Asking for help means I'm weak.

He needs belonging, money sense and permission to reach out.

Why he'd bounce

- Privilege-blind advice ("just network", "ask your family").
- Anything that wastes his scarce time or data.
- Content that makes him feel further behind.

USELESS TO DEEPAK

Generic "follow your passion" career fluff written for the already-advantaged.

MAGIC TO DEEPAK

Concrete money and career skills, a reminder that impostor feelings are normal, and a low-stakes way to ask for help.

Design implications

- 1 Teach money as a survival skill: budgeting, saving, scams and debt, plainly.
- 2 Normalise impostor syndrome and belonging; make help-seeking low-stakes.
- 3 Give realistic career navigation for those without networks or connections.
- 4 Respect his time and data: short, offline-friendly, no privilege assumptions.

Zoya, 21

Final-year student · urban college · finally herself, and dreading the holidays

"On campus I have a girlfriend and a chosen family. At home I have a mother lining up boys. I live two lives and I'm exhausted."

LIVES	Hostel; out and accepted at college, closeted at home.
MONEY	Family-funded, which complicates her independence.
DEVICES	Private phone; active in queer communities online.
SUPPORT	A strong chosen family; a loving but unknowing biological one.
PRIOR ED	Self-taught on identity; underserved on adult queer health and rights.

Two lives. College gave Zoya the space to come out, fall in love and find her people. Graduation threatens all of it: financial dependence, marriage pressure, and a family that doesn't know. She needs grown-up support on relationships, health and rights as a queer woman, and a way to think through coming out, or not, on her own terms and timeline, without it costing her everything.

What she wants

- To keep her relationship and her self-respect after college.
- Grown-up, inclusive info on queer relationships, health and rights.
- Help thinking through family, marriage pressure and independence.
- Community and support that survives leaving campus.

The myth she carries

That she must choose between her family and herself, and that being out will cost her safety, money or a future.

It's my family or me.

Being out will ruin everything.

She needs options and agency, not a script written by someone who isn't her.

Why she'd bounce

- Straight-only relationship content that erases her.
- Naïve "just come out" advice that ignores real Indian-family risk.
- Anything that treats her identity as the problem.

ERASING TO ZOYA

Relationship and health content that assumes everyone is straight. She simply isn't in it.

MAGIC TO ZOYA

Inclusive adult guidance on her relationship and health, plus honest, safe ways to navigate family and independence.

Design implications

- 1 Be inclusive by default across relationships, health and rights, not a separate tab.
- 2 Respect agency on coming out: support her choice and timeline, never push.
- 3 Address real Indian-family and financial-dependence stakes honestly.
- 4 Connect to durable community and support beyond campus.

Meena, 20

Migrant worker · rural-to-urban, no college · independence the hard way

"I came to the city to earn. There's no hostel warden, no counsellor, no one. The supervisor says things, and I just need the job."

LIVES	Shared room with other migrant women; far from family.
WORK	Factory / domestic / retail; long hours, little protection.
MONEY	Earns and remits home; targeted by lenders and scams.
DEVICES	One basic smartphone; limited data; reads slowly.
SUPPORT	No campus, no counsellor; an NGO is the only safety net.

The forgotten majority. Most 18-22s in India are not on a campus; they are working, like Meena. She has independence and income, and also harassment with no complaints process, money she doesn't know how to protect, and health needs she can't easily meet. She is exactly the user that college-shaped products ignore, and exactly the one who most needs practical rights, money and safety knowledge, in her language, offline.

What she wants

- To be safe and treated with dignity at work.
- To protect and grow the money she earns.
- To access health care without shame or losing a day's wage.
- To know her rights and where to turn when they're broken.

Why she'd bounce

- College-centric, English, data-hungry content; none of it fits her life.
- Abstract "empowerment" with no concrete, usable step.
- Anything that risks her job or exposes her.

INVISIBLE TO MEENA

A campus-life app in English. It assumes a world she was never let into.

The myth she carries

That harassment is the price of a job, and that a woman alone in the city has only herself to blame for whatever happens.

Harassment is just part of the job.

A girl alone is asking for trouble.

She is unserved, not unreachable. Offline, in-language, practical reaches her.

MAGIC TO MEENA

An offline, spoken, local-language guide to her rights at work, her money and her health, with real help a tap away.

Design implications

- 1 Serve the non-college majority: offline, audio-first, local-language, on a basic phone.
- 2 Centre workplace rights and the POSH process in plain, usable terms.
- 3 Practical money and health: saving, scams, low-cost confidential care.
- 4 Route to real help (helplines, NGOs, labour bodies), discreetly and safely.

Aarti, 21

Final-year student at a local college · tier-2 town · her marriage is being arranged

"They're not forcing me, exactly. But the proposals are coming, the wedding is assumed, and nobody's asked me what I actually want."

LIVES	At home; local degree; limited mobility and independence.
MONEY	Dependent; no income of her own yet.
DEVICES	Phone with some privacy; active but careful online.
SUPPORT	A loving family with a fixed timeline; few outside allies.
PRIOR ED	Decent schooling; nothing on consent, rights or her own choices.

Her turn, on someone else's schedule. Aarti isn't being dragged to a mandap; she's being gently swept toward one. Marriage is the assumed next step, and her own preferences, about timing, about a partner, about working, are simply not part of the conversation. She isn't anti-marriage; she wants a say in it, and the knowledge to enter any relationship as an equal, with consent, rights and a sense of her own worth intact.

What she wants

- A real say in whether, when and whom she marries.
- To understand consent, equality and her rights within a marriage.
- Options she didn't know she had, framed without a family war.
- The confidence and language to be heard.

The myth she carries

That her marriage isn't hers to weigh in on, and that wanting a say makes her ungrateful or a bad daughter.

~~My marriage isn't my decision.~~

~~Wanting a say is being a bad daughter.~~

She needs agency and equality inside her reality, not a fantasy of escaping it.

Why she'd bounce

- Content that treats arranged marriage itself as the enemy.
- Urban assumptions about freedom she doesn't have.
- Anything the family could read as her "rebellious".

USELESS TO AARTI

A "leave and live your dream" message that ignores the family and town she actually lives in.

MAGIC TO AARTI

Tools to claim a say in her own marriage and to enter any relationship as an equal, with consent and rights she can name.

Design implications

- 1 Support agency within her reality: a say in marriage, not a lecture against it.
- 2 Teach consent, equality and rights inside relationships and marriage.
- 3 Give her language and confidence to be heard, without inviting a rupture.
- 4 Avoid urban-freedom assumptions; meet the tier-2, family-bound reality.

CAMPUS COUNSELLOR

Dr. Mehta, 45

College counsellor and student-welfare officer · one person, a campus in crisis

"I have thousands of students and a waiting list. By the time they reach me it's a crisis. I need something that helps them before that."

Reality

- One counsellor for a huge student body; demand vastly exceeds capacity.
- Sees the campus mental-health crisis, ragging, breakups, harassment, isolation.
- Many students arrive with no life skills and no prior sex education.
- Wants prevention and self-help to take load off, plus safe referral in.

What he needs from SwipeEd. Something he can recommend to a student at the moment of need, on consent, relationships, money, belonging or mental health, that is accurate, destigmatised and adult in tone, and that knows when to route a struggling student to real, human help. A first line of support that reaches the many he will never have time to see, and a clear referral path for those he must.

WRONG FOR HIM

Cheery "wellness" content that trivialises real distress, or anything that could shame a struggling student.

MAGIC TO DR. MEHTA

Credible, just-in-time self-help he can recommend by topic, with clear, safe escalation to a counsellor when it's needed.

Design implications

- 1 Build for just-in-time, recommend-by-topic use, not a fixed course.
- 2 Get mental-health content right; destigmatise, never trivialise.
- 3 Make referral explicit: know the limits, route to human help clearly.
- 4 Be deployable at campus scale with zero per-student admin.

Farhan, 33

NGO youth life-skills and livelihoods lead · reaches the youth no campus does

"My young people are working, not studying. They need rights, money sense and health, in their language, on a cheap phone, today."

Reality

- Runs life-skills and livelihoods programmes for working and first-gen youth.
- Serves migrants, women workers, school-leavers, far from any campus.
- Low resources, multilingual groups, patchy connectivity and devices.
- Priorities: financial literacy, workplace rights, health, safety.

UNUSABLE TO HIM

An online, English, campus-flavoured app. It fails his learners on every count.

What he needs from SwipeEd. Offline, in-language, practical content he can run with a group or hand to a young worker: money, rights, health and relationships pitched at real adult life, not campus life. A tool that extends his reach into exactly the 18-22s that mainstream products forget, and that respects their intelligence and their constraints at once.

MAGIC TO FARHAN

An offline, multilingual adulting-and-rights toolkit he can deliver to a group and the young worker can keep using alone.

Design implications

- 1 Offline-first, multilingual, low-resource; group-led and self-serve in one.
- 2 Prioritise money, workplace rights and health for working youth.
- 3 Pitch to adult life, not campus life; never condescend.
- 4 Connect to real services: banks, helplines, clinics, labour bodies.

What Chapter 6 must do differently.

Across all eight personas, one demand dominates: stop teaching and start equipping. These are adults, mostly unschooled in any of this, hitting real life at speed. Meet them at the moment of need, in their reality, as equals.

PRINCIPLE	BECAUSE	SHOWS UP AS
Adult-to-adult, wry not earnest	They've left school and won't tolerate a module or a lecture.	The brand's dark, wry-but-kind register; respect and privacy.
Just-in-time, not a course	They learn when they hit a wall, not on a syllabus.	Searchable, on-demand, recommend-by-topic; no forced linearity.
Consent and dating for real	Apps, alcohol, hookups and breakups, with no prior education.	Honest, non-judgmental consent, safety and relationship content.
Health, money, rights as survival	Clinics, rent, scams, harassment and debt are live now.	Practical adulting: SRH, financial literacy, POSH and rights.
Mind, loneliness, belonging	New city, campus crisis, impostor syndrome, isolation.	Normalise, cope, and route to real mental-health help.
The male arc continues	The manosphere kid is now dating and miserable.	Exit through his pain; a respected masculinity that works.
Serve the non-college majority	Most 18-22s in India are working, not on a campus.	Offline, in-language, rights and money first; via NGOs.
Family at a distance	Marriage, money and reputation still pull from afar.	Agency within reality; navigate family without rupture.

The same principles, on the nine Chapter 6 games

GAME	THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS
Consent, For Real (g44)	Adult settings: alcohol, a room, ongoing and revocable consent; for Ananya and Rohan alike.
Swipe Right? (g45)	Dating-app safety and reality: meet public, ghosting, nudes pressure, you owe no one.
Real Relationships (g46)	Healthy vs toxic, conflict and breakups; inclusive of Zoya; the exit Rohan needs.
Own Your Health (g47)	Adult SRH: clinics, contraception, confidential, stigma-free care; for everyone, Meena included.
Money & Independence (g48)	Budgeting, saving, scams and debt; Deepak's and Meena's survival skill.
Mind & Belonging (g49)	Loneliness, impostor syndrome, the campus crisis; cope and route to real help.
Find Your Feet (g52)	Career anxiety, comparison and rejection; realistic paths without networks.
Equal & Confident (g50)	Equality and the double standard as a young adult; confidence for Aarti, a rethink for Rohan.

Know Your Rights (g51)

POSH, tenancy, consumer and digital rights; plain and usable for Meena and Deepak.

Next: Chapter 7 (building a life: partnership, home, the if/when/whether of family), or a Chapter 6 game-by-game redesign built on this brief.